Representative Donald Jackson (R-CA) pointed out that India had actively put up “stumbling blocks” for the US.[61]

One of those obstacles was Nehru’s reiteration that foreign forces en route to Indochina would not be permitted to fly over India. Representative Frances P. Bolton (R-OH) wondered if Indian policymakers realized that their attitude on Indochina was going “to bring communism right to their own doors.”[62] Appropriations Committee chairman Senator Styles Bridges and others said the US should keep in mind Nehru’s refusal when considering aid to India. Senator Homer Ferguson (R-MI) added that India’s action “gave aid and comfort to the communist world.”[63]

Congressional criticism had an impact in India—but not the kind intended. Nehru said that while “it would be grossly unfair … to judge the United States by the speeches of some Senators … inevitably there are reactions in India to speeches and writings in the press.”[64] Reports indicated that even Indian friends of the US and critics of Nehru were disappointed by the outburst against India in Congress.[65] The prime minister also expressed doubts to his ambassador in Washington about accepting American aid since the two countries were at such loggerheads.[66]

There would be further doubts, as the US turned to a different approach to contain communism in Asia: collective security. US ambassador to India George V. Allen told Congress this was the source of the “biggest difference” between the US and India.[67] And when the administration subsequently announced the consideration of a collective security organization in Asia—the Southeast Asia Treaty Organization (SEATO)—this only further exacerbated US-India tensions.[68]

Problematic Partnerships (1953–1955)

Like Acheson before him, Dulles noted that the US and India did not necessarily have differences on ultimate interests or objectives. The real crux of the problem was India’s method of achieving those goals.[69] One key example of its different approach was the Indian engagement of China. India, too, saw Eisenhower’s chosen means as increasing India’s difficulties. This was particularly true of collective security, which made Pakistan part of the solution from Washington’s perspective, rather than part of the problem as Delhi saw it.